

# Cramming every memory you have into the toast

8 findings · 13-step checklist · 8 sources · [cheatgrid.com](https://cheatgrid.com)

Leaving a story out doesn't prove it mattered less to you, even if keeping everything in feels like the only way to avoid picking a favorite. **Your closing line** decides more than the count of stories you fit in.

## THE GOAL

You're trying to protect the story that matters most and land your closing line well, not to fit in every memory you have.

## CHECKLIST

**You have a full draft of every story you want to tell, and you're sitting down to cut it to the length you'll say.**

- ☐ Read the whole draft out loud once, straight through, with a timer running, and pick the length you're aiming for.
- ☐ Circle the one moment in it that hit hardest while you read it aloud, whether it was the laugh or the lump in your throat.
- ☐ Write your closing line on its own line before you touch anything else, and read it back once.
- ☐ Cut every other story down to one sentence. If the sentence doesn't hold up alone, the story goes.
- ☐ For any story you're keeping mainly because you already wrote it out, cross it out and see if you miss it.
- ☐ Pull any pleasant-but-optional story out of **the middle** of your running order first.
- ☐ If a story needs someone's name, job or year explained first, add one line for it or cut the story.
- ☐ Put the story that hit hardest when you read it aloud last in the order, right before your closing line.
- ☐ Read the full running order out loud once, checking each story leads into the next without needing 'anyway' to bridge them.
- ☐ Check how long this draft runs. If it's past the length you picked, cut **a whole story** rather than trim a line from each one.
- ☐ Say your closing line out loud on its own, three times, until it stops trailing off at the end.
- ☐ Read the finished speech to one outside listener, ask what stuck with them afterward, then cut whatever made their attention wander.
- ☐ Write the final running order on a card in large print, numbered, and keep the card somewhere you'll reach for it.

## THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1** You trust a story belongs in the toast because you wrote it, not because **it will land** with the room.
- 2** Don't keep a story just for writing it. Its place in the toast is earned by the story alone.
- 3** You will overestimate how often a story's real point lands with the room, even with extra context added.

## What the extra story is really proving

### KNOW

You trust a story belongs in the toast because you wrote it, not because **it will land** with the room.

People who built simple things like furniture or paper crafts rated their own clumsy work as good as an expert's, and expected others to agree. [Source 1](#)

**DON'T**

Don't keep a story just for writing it. Its place in the toast is earned by the story alone.

People stick with something once real money, work or hours are already in it, mainly to avoid feeling that effort went to waste. [Source 2](#)

## What the room will actually remember

**KNOW**

How your toast is remembered comes down to its single strongest moment and how it ends. Length barely enters into it.

For people who watched longer film clips, the peak moment and the ending decided the rating, not the added length. [Source 3](#)

**DO**

Protect your closing line above everything else you're tempted to cut for time, since how something ends can outweigh everything that came before it.

People who endured a painful cold-water trial chose to repeat the longer, harsher version, because it eased off before it finished. [Source 4](#)

**KNOW**

A story placed in the middle of your toast is most likely to **vanish from memory**, however good it is.

People asked to freely recall lists of words remembered the first few and the last few more often than anything from the middle. [Source 5](#)

**KNOW**

The exact words of a story fade from memory first. What the room keeps afterward is the shape of what happened rather than the specific details you worked hard to include.

People consistently kept the general meaning of what they'd read or seen long after the exact wording had slipped from memory. [Source 6](#)

## What the room actually notices

**DON'T**

Don't add extra time to your toast hoping it will read as more sincere. A short, clear moment reads just as accurately as a long moment.

Judgments people made from clips under two minutes were just as accurate as judgments made from four- or five-minute clips. [Source 7](#)

**KNOW**

You will overestimate how often a story's real point lands with the room, even with extra context added.

Speakers who explained an ambiguous sentence expected listeners to understand it more often than the listeners did. [Source 8](#)

## Sources

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## Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Speeches at occasions at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

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